

winter food. Later, though, the carnival kicks off, with jesters, singers, onion-costumed locals, and wild confetti battles long into the winter night.

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Guangzhou International Food Festival, China

Guangzhou is rightly proud of being said to have the best food in all of China. People flock from nearby Hong Kong and Macau to dine here, and never more so than during this annual exhibition of its culinary prowess. Lots of different cuisines are on display, but don't miss the Cantonese delicacies.

Nabanna, Dhaka, Bangladesh

The name Nabanna means "new food" and, in the Bangladeshi countryside, it's one of the most important events of the year. The rice harvest is celebrated with symbolic foods such as *payesh* (rice pudding) and *pitha* (rice flour cakes), as well as traditional music and dances, and offerings to the Hindu goddess of wealth, Lakshmi.

NORTH AMERICA

Kona Coffee Festival, Big Island, Hawaii, USA

Wake up and smell the coffee at Hawaii's oldest food festival. It's the rich volcanic soil that's said to give this pure arabica its rare depth of flavor and aroma, prized by connoisseurs the world over. No wonder the people of the Kona district choose to honor it with pageants, parades, competitions, cultural events, and plantation tastings. www.konacoffeefest.com

Chitlin' Strut, Salley, South Carolina, USA

Some say that, for a true taste of the south, nothing quite beats a chitlin'. Others prefer the fried chicken or barbecued ribs to deep-fried pig's intestines, but everyone's in agreement that a great time is to be had at the Salley Chitlin' Strut, with parades, a pancake breakfast, carnival rides, dancing, and the great Hawg Call competition. www.chitlinstrut.com

Festival Gourmet International, Puerto Vallarta, Riviera Nayarit, Mexico

Drawing culinary superstars from around the world to host events such as Chef's Table and Winemaker's Night dinners, Gourmet Safaris, and even a Chefs' Hell Raising Party, it's not

difficult to see why this festival on Mexico's Pacific Riviera has made its mark. www.festivalgourmet.com

Cornucopia, Whistler, British Columbia, Canada

With snow already thick on the slopes, it's hard to imagine anyone is in town for anything else. But now's the time that serious foodies make a pilgrimage to Whistler for one of the most exciting and informative gastronomic events of the year — this is a wining and dining experience to beat any off-piste adventure. www.whistlercornucopia.com

DECEMBER

EUROPE

Les Glorieuses de Bresse, France

With its red comb, white body, and blue legs, the Bresse chicken is the *tricolore* emblem of France — and rightly so, since it is often judged the finest poultry in the land. Four towns in this Burgundian region each host a day of this fête in its honor, with gourmet markets, tastings, culinary demonstrations, and dinners at which the *coq* is king. www.glorieusesdebresse.com

Sagra del Singhiale, Suvereto, Italy

The narrow streets, squares, and cloisters of this ancient Tuscan town take on a medieval flavor for the Wild Boar Festival. Pageants, archery, fencing, jesters, and even human chess games all contribute to the magical atmosphere. The focus of the feasting is, of course, roast wild boar, served with grilled polenta and wild mushrooms and plenty of local wine.

Christkindlesmarkt, Nuremberg, Germany

The Christmas Angel opens Nuremberg's magical old-world market, when the city square sparkles and the air is filled with the delicious aromas of mulled wine, hot chestnuts, roast sausages, gingerbread, fruit loaves, and marzipan candies. Hundreds of decorated stands form a "Little Town of Wood and Cloth." www.christkindlesmarkt.de

Fiera dia Castagna, Bocognano, Corsica, France

Corsicans call the chestnut the "tree of life," and its flour is used in bread, polenta, cakes, and even beer. Chestnut jelly, honey, and liqueurs are highly prized, as is charcuterie from the local boars that feed on the nuts. As the island's most

important crop it truly deserves this annual celebration, which involves competitions, demonstrations, and market stands piled high with chestnut products.

THE MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA

Franschhoek Cap Classique and Champagne Festival, South Africa

With a French heritage going back over 300 years, Franschhoek is understandably proud of its reputation as the gourmet capital of South Africa. Set in "the most beautiful wine valley in the world," it celebrates its good fortune, presenting its own Cap Classique bubbly alongside the great names of Champagne. Mouthwatering French delicacies are served to complement the wine. www.franschhoek.org.za

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Taste Festival, Hobart, Tasmania, Australia

Charming Sullivan's Cove, in Tasmania's capital city, plays host to ten days of feasts and fun, culminating on New Year's Eve with a grand fireworks display over the tranquil harbor waters. Circus acts, buskers, stilt-walkers, and street theater entertain the kids, while the grown-ups can enjoy artisan beers, fine Tasmanian wines, and Tasting Tours of local gourmet cuisine.

NORTH AMERICA

Night of the Radishes, Oaxaca, Mexico

Leave radishes in the ground for months until they grow up to two feet long. Then dig them up and carve them into fantastic sculptures of Nativity scenes, dancers, warriors, folk heroes, trees, and buildings. Sounds crazy, but that's what happens at this extraordinary one-of-a-kind Christmas festival in Oaxaca.

Inn-to-Inn Cookie and Candy Tour, White Mountains, New Hampshire, USA

What better way to get into the holiday spirit than to make a snowy tour around the quaint inns of New Hampshire, all decked out in their Christmas finery? Visitors are welcomed with handmade cookies, candy canes, and other festive treats, and can vote on stunning gingerbread sculptures, collect family recipes, and depart with visions of sugarplums to last a lifetime.

SOUTH AMERICA

Santuranticuy, Cusco, Peru

Plaza del Armas becomes a vast, illuminated Nativity scene in the days before Christmas Eve's breathtaking Santuranticuy ("saints for sale") market. Country people flock into town with ceramic manger figures to sell, including the Andean baby Jesus, El Niño Manuelito. There's sweet rum punch, roast corn, and *panetón* cake for those who can afford it, while hot chocolate and fruited biscuits are given to the poor.

From left to right Blessing food at the Phuket Vegetarian Festival in October; stands lit up at night during Christkindlesmarkt, in Nuremberg's central square; singers and dancers perform in traditional dress at the Fête des Dattes in Erfoud, Morocco; a craftsman displays figures carved from radishes during Mexico's Night of the Radishes celebrations in December

